II.

The academic field of geopolitics began with Halford Mackinder and his oft-quoted, oft-misunderstood "heartland" thesis. Mackinder's famous 1904 article, "The Geographical Pivot of History," in fact discussed only briefly the idea of the heartland, essentially steppe Eurasia, as the ultimate goal of any world power.[12] Mackinder may have written that "whoever controls the heartland controls the world," but his real insight was into the struggle over the "rimlands," which both guard and give access to the heartland. The rimlands properly include the European peninsula of the Eurasian landmass, as well as the littoral areas of Asia and the Middle East. The great struggles for world power that followed on the heels of Mackinder's article in fact took place in the rimlands, and over the course of the twentieth century, the greatest economic growth took place in those same rimlands. In the second decade of the twenty-first century they have once again become areas of competition. As Wess Mitchell and Jakub Grygiel wrote, it is the rimlands that both revanchist Russia under Vladimir Putin and revisionist China seem to be trying to contest.[13]

Four decades after Mackinder's original thesis, during the darkest days of World War II, the Yale geopolitical thinker Nicholas John Spykman returned to the rimland thesis and further modified it to take into account recent great-power warfare in the twentieth century. In a posthumously published book titled *The Geography of the Peace* (1944), Spykman provided the insight that it is in the rimlands that the real struggle for mastery has taken place.[14] More importantly, he argued that attaining control of the "marginal" or "inner" seas adjacent to the rimlands, bordered by the offshore "outer crescent" of island nations like Great Britain and Japan, was the prerequisite to dominating the rimlands. Thus, according to Spykman, the most crucial waterways for global power were the North Sea and the Mediterranean in Europe, the Persian Gulf and littoral waters of the western Indian Ocean in the Middle East, and the East and South China Seas, along with the Yellow Sea, in Asia.